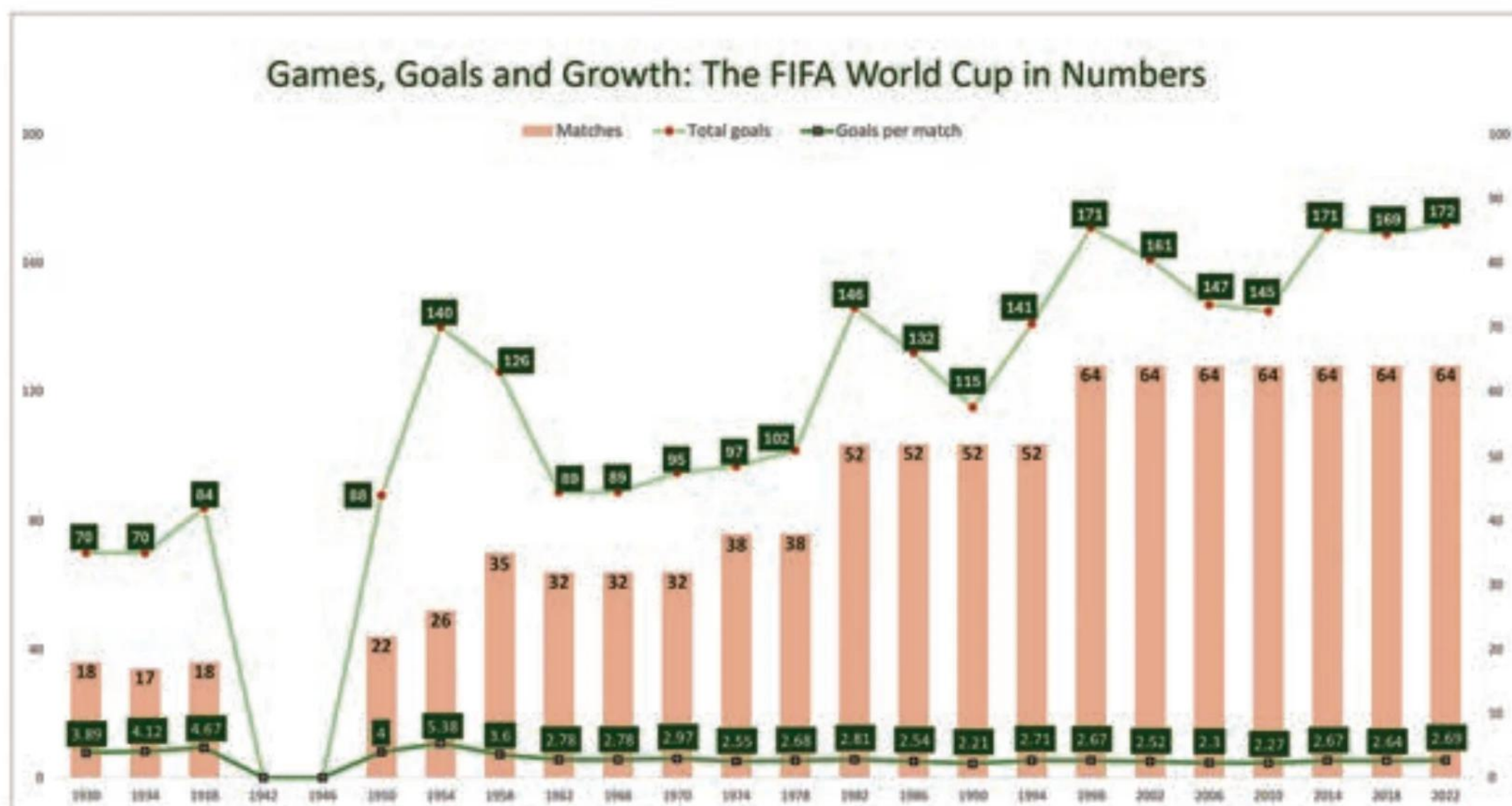




Reinhard Grindel had opposed expansion, citing the “considerable weaknesses” highlighted in FIFA factsheets.

“At the DFB, we’re fundamentally convinced that the tried-and-tested model of 32 participating nations should be held,” he had said in 2017.

The paradox of expansion

João Havelange, with Sepp Blatter as General Secretary, oversaw the World Cup’s evolution from 16 to 24

teams in 1982 and then to 32 in 1998.

Spain ‘82 loosened the game: goals per game rose (2.68 to 2.81), but matches lacked balance — El Salvador’s 1-10 loss to Hungary remains one of the most one-sided matches in the tournament’s history.

On the other hand, France ‘98 tightened it. Goals per game fell from 2.71 to 2.67 despite an increase in total goals (141 to 171). Margins reduced too — Spain’s 6-1 win felt

dominant, not excessive.

Infantino would know that expansion does not follow a script as he looks to build his legacy with a bigger World Cup. 48 teams will play 104 matches over more than a month, with players arriving after gruelling domestic seasons.

The question now is no longer whether expansion is needed — that ship has sailed. What remains is this: at what point does more begin to feel like less?

Matches with biggest ranking gaps



76

Belgium (9) vs New Zealand (85) – Matchday 3; Brazil (6) vs Curacao (82) – Matchday 2

74

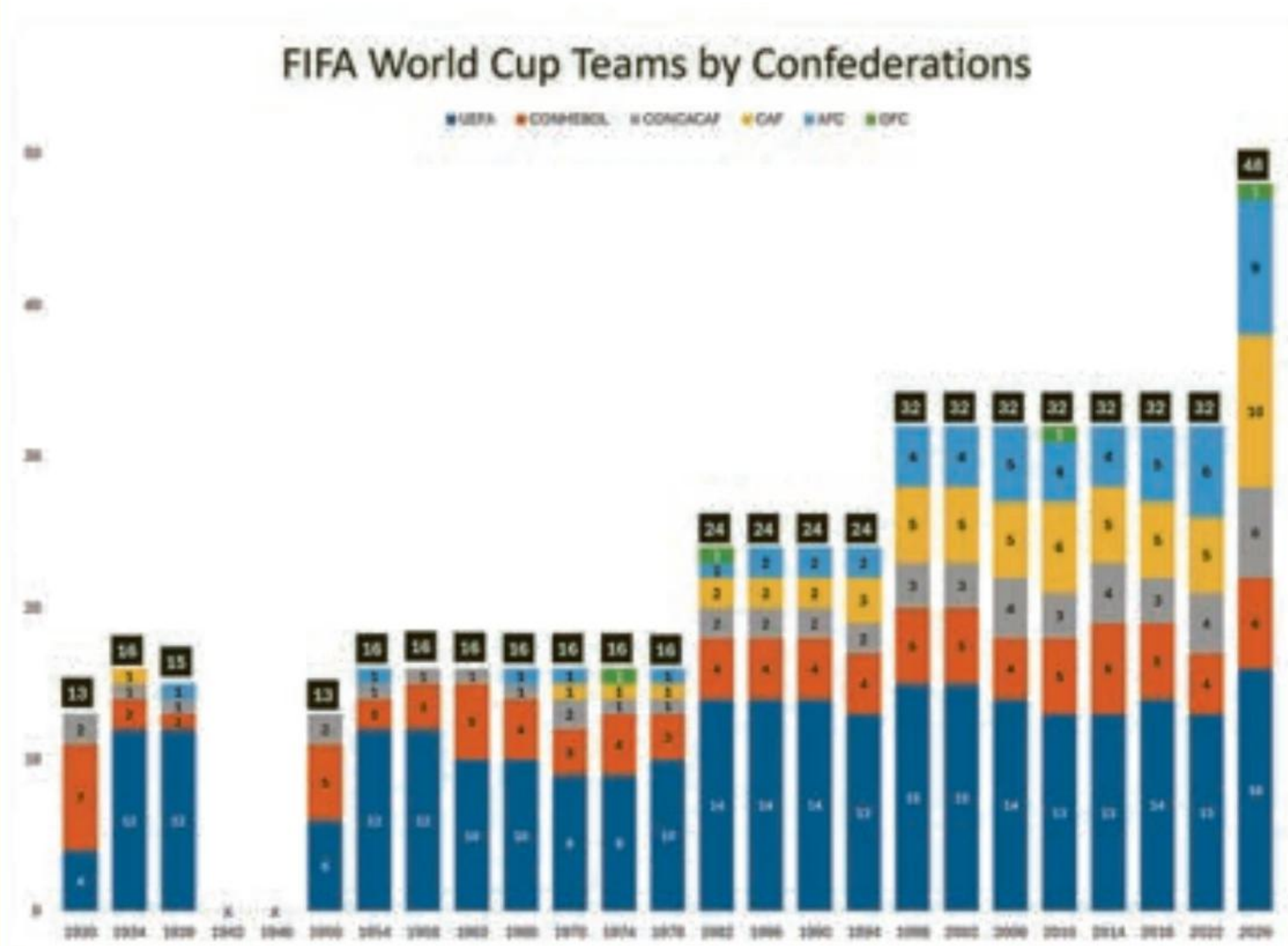
Morocco (8) vs Curacao (82) – Matchday 3

72

Germany (10) vs Curacao (82) – Matchday 1

70

England (4) vs Ghana (74) – Matchday 2



*1942 and 1946 editions were suspended due to World War II. Graph data source: FIFA